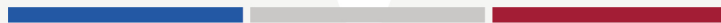




MIT SLOAN SCHOOL OF MANAGEMENT
MIT SCHWARZMAN COLLEGE OF COMPUTING



MODULE 2 UNIT 3
Media Set Video 1 Part 1 Transcript

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Introduction

PAUL MCDONAGH-SMITH: So, we're very excited, very pleased, to be joined today by Dmitri. Dmitri, would you like to take a moment just to let us know who you are and what you do?

DMITRI TCHEREVIK: Sure, thank you, Paul. Great to be here. I'm a founder of a company called AnyQuest. It's a generative AI platform, and we help companies implement AI, find the best use cases, and scale them across the enterprise.

From concept to operational reality

MCDONAGH-SMITH: Thank you. So, our first question for you today is that our participants, the business leaders who are on this course, they've just finished their first module where they built their understanding of what agentic AI actually is, the architecture, the move from chatbots to agents, the idea of agentic workflows.

From your vantage point, having helped so many enterprises actually deploy this technology, could you take us inside one agentic workflow that's been operationally consequential for one of your customers? Could you perhaps walk us through what it does, what it replaces, and importantly, something about its design that they couldn't have anticipated when they first sketched it out on a whiteboard?

TCHEREVIK: Absolutely. So, I think for agents, sales and marketing is a good place to start, because the content is there, content is publicly available, it's easy to orchestrate, easy to automate. So, one good example is lead enrichment and personalization. So, this one company, they do webinars periodically. There are 60, 70 people who attend. They usually like to follow up with some kind of message after this. So, they used an agent to then analyze every participant, build their profile, and then find lookalikes in their CRM. And then based on what they have already sold to similar people, they can now create a personalized follow-up message. So, they were able to build this kind of an agent and their click-through rate for follow-up emails went up 10x.

MCDONAGH-SMITH: Also, it's interesting the fact that they take a step back from the actual experience, they look at what happened, they recognize some of the patterns and use that then to actually amplify the value of the agentic workflows.

TCHEREVIK: Yeah, pattern is always important. That is what agents do. They can automate patterns so they can recognize patterns. But also the scale. Previously one, two people could never handle 60, 70 leads after a webinar, but agents do that very easily. But then also cross-reference, analyze information, find patterns, do this kind of matching, and then draft a very personal message that is something that AI can do.

The decomposition heuristic

MCDONAGH-SMITH: So Dimitri, at the heart of designing an agentic workflow is task decomposition. But where in practice, in your experience, does that line actually sit? For example, when you're with a client designing an agentic workflow, what's your heuristic for when something should be a single agentic step versus perhaps two, three, or four? What signals show you you've perhaps gone too granular or not yet granular enough?

TCHEREVIK: Yeah, so by now, almost everybody deploy chatbots, enterprise chatbots, and people use them all the time. So, the very first heuristic would be, do you repeat certain prompts in a certain sequence again and again and again? So, if you do that, that is a great candidate for automation, using an agent, because the agent can repeat those prompts for you.

So, another good example is that you type in a prompt, you're using the best prompt engineering practices, but the output is still very flat. It still is not giving you what you would like. That tells you that the model cannot cope. It's either too many different tools or the data is too complex. So, that is a good point where you may want to start thinking about task decomposition. And this all comes through practice. It's kind of bottom-up.

Another example where you may want to go top-down is that if you know that your document is very complex, you want your agent to review a 200-page credit agreement. It is just not, you know, the models today cannot handle that. So again, that's a good candidate for task decomposition. So, in general, it's either you do something repeatedly, you want to automate it, or you know that the model is just not good enough yet to handle that kind of a task.

MCDONAGH-SMITH: Do you sometimes find it challenging to, when you're working with clients, to help them understand what this task or should we say workflow decomposition actually needs to look like? Because on a surface level, they might think, well, this is something we are very kind of skilled and accomplished at already. How do you help them to be more deliberate and perhaps see the decomposition through a slightly different lens?

TCHEREVIK: Yeah, so there is often resistance or skepticism. Can an agent really do this work that we do so well? So, very often, it can be a time pressure. You know, you cannot process 60 leads within a day, or you cannot process 60 discovery interviews within a week. So, under that kind of time pressure, you may want to consider using an agent. So, that very often is a good opportunity to deploy AI.

Another one is that, with AI, you can do something that was previously impossible. Let's say you're a consulting company, you want to do client discovery. With your team, you can do six interviews, let's say, in a week. But with AI, you can do 60. So, it's either a force multiplier or it is something that is giving you time.

MCDONAGH-SMITH: Did you understand all the concepts covered in this video? If you'd like to review any of the content, please click on the chapter menu.